How to talk about non-production projects in interviews

Talk about them as **internal prototypes or proof-of-concept solutions**, not as "unfinished projects." Be honest that they are not in production, but emphasize the real problem, your design decisions, what works today, what you validated, and what productionization would require. Interviewers care more about your engineering judgment than whether a prototype reached production. [1] [2] [3]

Use this framing

Say:

> "This was an internal prototype I built to solve a real workflow problem. It is not yet in production, but it is functional and demonstrates the end-to-end approach I would take to productionize it."

Avoid:

- "It is just a small project."
- "It did not work completely."
- "I only made a demo."
- Claiming it was deployed or used by many users if it was not.

Instead, use accurate labels: **proof of concept**, **internal prototype**, **MVP**, **pilot**, or **working prototype**. Being transparent about team contribution and project status is important; do not embellish or imply production use that did not happen. [3] [4] [1]

A simple interview structure

Use **Context → Action → Result → Next steps** in about 2 minutes:

1. **Context:** What manual problem or inefficiency existed?
2. **Action:** What you personally designed and built, including key technical decisions.
3. **Result:** What worked, what you tested, and any measurable outcome.
4. **Next steps:** What you would add for production—security, deployment, monitoring, scalability, user feedback, or integration.

This structure keeps the answer focused and prevents you from overexplaining every technical detail. [2] [5] [6]

Example: Python migration app

Question: “Tell me about a project you built.”

> “At my reinsurance company, teams were manually loading module-specific CSV files into SQL Server. I built a Python-based data-migration prototype that reads files from designated folders, validates their structure and content, loads them into SQL Server staging tables, and archives successfully processed files.
> I designed it around batch processing and auditability: each run records the files processed, rows loaded, validation failures, and archive status. I also added reconciliation checks between source-file counts/totals and database records so users can quickly identify incomplete or incorrect loads.
> It is currently an internal prototype rather than a production deployment, but it demonstrates the full ingestion-to-validation workflow. For production, I would add role-based access, centralized logging, scheduling, retry/recovery logic, and integration with our data-quality monitoring process.”

This is strong because it shows initiative, ETL knowledge, data-quality thinking, and awareness of production requirements.[7] [8] [1]

Example: RAG chatbot

> “I built a document-based RAG assistant in .NET using a locally hosted Phi-4 model. The goal was to let users ask questions about internal documents instead of manually searching through files.
> I implemented document ingestion, chunking, embeddings, vector retrieval, prompt construction, and response generation. I focused on grounded answers by returning source references so users can verify where an answer came from. I also added guardrails for out-of-scope questions and cases where the retrieved evidence is insufficient.
> It is a working prototype, not a production system. I tested it using a small set of representative questions and reviewed whether the correct source was retrieved and whether the response was supported by the document. The next step would be a larger evaluation set, user feedback collection, security review, and deployment with monitoring.”

This turns “I made a chatbot” into evidence of RAG architecture, evaluation thinking, guardrails, and responsible AI awareness.[9] [10] [2]

Example: AI regression testing app

> “I am building an AI-based regression-testing prototype to reduce repetitive manual testing and catch regressions earlier. The idea is to define test cases, execute them automatically, and compare current results against a baseline after code, prompt, or model changes.
> For LLM-related checks, I am combining deterministic validations—such as schema, required fields, and response-format checks—with evaluation of whether the answer is complete, grounded, and consistent with expected behavior. The platform will also classify failures and generate a comparison report showing new failures, fixed issues, and unchanged results.
> It is in progress, but the design goal is to make AI changes testable in the same disciplined way as traditional software changes. The next step is integrating it into CI/CD and expanding the evaluation dataset.”

This shows you understand modern AI quality engineering: regression tests, evaluation suites, baselines, and CI/CD.[10] [11] [12]

Handle follow-up questions

Prepare honest answers for these:

Question	Good response approach
“Why is it not in production?”	Explain the real constraint: approval, data access, security review, integration, prioritization, or dependency on another team.
“How did you validate it?”	Describe test data, edge cases, reconciliation checks, evaluation questions, or manual review.
“What was hardest?”	Choose one concrete challenge: inconsistent CSV formats, hallucinations, retrieval quality, schema mismatches, or defining expected outputs.
“What would you change?”	Mention a realistic improvement: better error handling, monitoring, security, evaluation coverage, or architecture.
“Was it used by anyone?”	Be precise: “I demonstrated it to X team,” “I used it for my own testing,” or “It is ready for a pilot, pending approval.”
“What was the impact?”	Use honest scope metrics: files processed, records handled, manual steps removed, test cases created, or time saved in your own testing.

Never invent production usage, user counts, or business savings. A credible scope metric is better than a fabricated impact number.[4] [13] [1]

Turn weakness into strength

A non-production project can actually show maturity if you explain the path to production:

> “I deliberately treated this as a prototype first. Before productionizing it, I wanted to validate the workflow, identify data-quality issues, and define the evaluation criteria. The next phase would focus on security, access control, deployment, monitoring, and stakeholder feedback.”

This shows you understand that enterprise AI is not only about building a model—it is about making a system reliable, governed, testable, and safe to use. [2] [9] [10]

Practice formula

For each project, memorize this 30-second opening:

> "I built a **[type of solution]** to solve **[specific problem]**. I used **[main technologies]** to implement **[key capabilities]**. It is currently a **[prototype/MVP]**, and I validated it through **[testing/evaluation method]**. The next step would be **[production requirement]**."

Then be ready to go deeper on architecture, trade-offs, failures, and improvements. Practice the full answer aloud, but keep it conversational rather than memorized word-for-word. [14] [15] [2]

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1. https://www.oregon.gov/DCBS/jobs/Pages/the-STAR-method.aspx
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